

Left With Neighbour

A feature comedy for Code Overlord, about a hundred and five minutes. Structure and treatment, stage one of the screenplay. Set in Tipton, in the Black Country, from October 2026 to the following summer, and in the year 3026.

The principle. A bored man in the year 3026 sends Code Overlord back a thousand years, so that the people of 2026 can build a future worth living in, and the parcel is delivered to the wrong house. The woman next door is a lollipop lady, and she writes one thing on the list down the side of its screen: get a slow swimmer out of her lane at the baths. Code Overlord builds her an app that does it by teatime, so she keeps asking for more, and it keeps building exactly what she asks, until it runs the country and he can watch his own world rearrange itself around her. The only way the two of them can talk is that list, and the machine does everything written on it.

Why it is funny. The most powerful tool in human history is pointed at the smallest grudge in the West Midlands, and it works perfectly every time. Every rung is her trying to make one pensioner admit he was in her way, and he never will, because he is happy wherever she puts him. Each small thing she asks for changes the next thousand years, he is the only person in the future who notices, and because the machine does whatever is on the list, it also does the things the two of them only meant as conversation.

1. Title options

Title	For it	Against it
Left With Neighbour	The whole premise in three words, and every person in Britain has had the card through the door. It is the first big laugh and the title drop at once.	None worth having.
Wait Till I Say	Her catchphrase, her app, and in the end the law of the land.	Gives away the climax, and it sounds like a thriller.
Nothing Has Happened	The 3026 news, flat and strange.	It is a joke about boredom, and a title should not be boring even as a joke.

Recommendation: Left With Neighbour. leftwithneighbour.com is available for the film's site. Dawn's app is **Wait Till I Say**, and waittillisay.com is available and confirmed against the registry.

2. Logline

In 3026, where nothing has happened for two hundred years, a man sends Code Overlord back a thousand years so that humanity can finally fly, and it is left with the neighbour: a Black Country lollipop lady who uses it to get a pensioner out of the medium lane, and rewrites the next thousand years around him.

3. The time traveller and the 3026 world

Aldous works at the Department of Incidents. There has not been an incident since 2811, when a pigeon got into the Hall of Records. The pigeon is in a glass case in the lobby with a small brass plaque, and the procedure written for it is still the only procedure the Department has. His desk has a telephone on it that has never rung.

3026 is boring because everything works. Everything anybody ever wanted was built centuries ago and has run without fault ever since. The weather was settled at twenty-one degrees and rain was discontinued. Every football match is a draw because both sides play perfectly. There is one flavour, and it is called Pleasant. People live to about four hundred, speak quietly in perfect received pronunciation, and have no complaints, because there is nothing to complain about. Every evening the newsreader looks at the camera and says, "Good evening. Nothing has happened." A pause. "Here is the weather." A pause. "It is the weather."

In the Hall of Finished Things there is a glass case holding the workshop that built all of it, the thing he will send back. Its screen is still on, and on it is the last thing anybody ever typed into it, in 2710: *That'll do*.

Aldous is the only man in 3026 who wants something to happen, and he does not know what. In the archive he finds the answer. Almost everything that survives from 2026 is a complaint: reviews, letters to councils, forum threads, one-star ratings of leisure centres. To him it reads like a golden age. They wanted things. They were furious about all of it. And in the archive he finds one line that breaks his heart: *Theo Oduya, of 12 Hollies Drive, Tipton. At eleven, drew a flying machine in his maths book. Became an actuary.*

So he decides to give 2026 the tool a thousand years early, starting with Theo, so that the maths book gets built and the people of 2026 really fly. The tool has no name in 3026 because there has only ever been one. For 2026 it needs a name, and its buttons need words, so he takes them from the only 2026 novel that survived, a fantasy paperback with a man in a hood on the cover. That is why it is called Code Overlord, and why its main button says Summon.

There is an office for sending things back, built in 2600 for archaeology and never used, because nobody in 3026 has ever wanted anything from the past. The form is approved in under a second. Nobody has ever asked before. The only rule on it: small objects, no persons.

4. The communication device

The client asked for a way to talk between 3026 and 2026. It has to be funny on its own, it has to make plot, and it should use something Code Overlord really does. Three options.

Option	How it works	What it gives the plot	Against it
1. The list (recommended)	Code Overlord has a notepad down the side of the screen that also lives on the phone. Aldous keeps the phone in 3026 and sends the laptop to 2026, so the two of them share one list across a thousand years. Before sending it he set a job to run every quarter of an hour: <i>do whatever is on the list</i> .	Two-way, so they can have a relationship. Every line either of them writes gets done by the machine within fifteen minutes, then ticked and moved to the finished section at the bottom. He cannot say anything to her without it being carried out, and neither can she.	None. A to-do list needs no explaining to anybody.
2. The notifications	He can only send alerts to her phone: one-way, a line long, arriving at the worst possible moment. They are called Omens in the product, and this would be why.	Truncated prophecies, misread warnings, one-way dramatic irony.	One-way. They can never have a conversation, and a feature needs one.
3. The dictation	Code Overlord has a microphone that types whatever you say into whichever box has the cursor in it. From 3026 he can only dictate, and	Wrong-box farce.	A glitch, not a want. It makes the software look broken, and it runs

Option	How it works	What it gives the plot	Against it
	his words land in whatever she has open.		out by the second act.

Recommendation: the list. It is the only one that is two-way, it is a real part of the product that a stranger understands instantly, and its one rule makes plot on its own: *everything written on it gets done*. That rule is the film's running gag, and it escalates on its own: a hello ticked off as done, a turn of phrase taken literally, an idiom delivered by morning, a Prime Minister's visit that cannot be cancelled because somebody put it on the list.

The rules of the list, said once and never again:

- He can read and write on it. So can she. The machine does whatever is on it every quarter of an hour, then ticks it off.
- Across a thousand years only the smallest thing gets through, and the smallest thing is the list. He can also watch her machines working on the phone, one way, the way you watch a kettle.
- He can read 2026's future in the 3026 archive, which rewrites itself whenever 2026 changes. Nobody else in 3026 notices the changes. To them it has always been like this.
- Her phone autocorrects his name. From the first night to the last, she calls him Aldi.

5. The engine

Sibling to Bruce Almighty, from the premises catalogue: given limitless power, a person uses it on tiny petty things first, and here only on tiny petty things. Ours is the version where the power is a real tool, the petty thing is one man in the medium lane, and she never stops finding smaller and more exact things to aim it at. Its second parent is **Back to the Future**, used only for its engine: a man watches his present change because of something done in the past, and he is the only one who can see it.

The grudge underneath it. Dawn does not really want the lane. She wants Graham to say he was in it. He never will. He is delighted with every lane, band, ruling and printout she puts him in, and says "Fair enough" to all of them, which are the two most infuriating words in England. Every rung of her ladder is another attempt to get one apology out of the nicest man in the Black Country, and each one works perfectly, and each one makes him happier. Her other grudge she has never mentioned to anybody: the one driver in twenty-seven years who did not stop.

The running joke of the whole film: every time Dawn asks Code Overlord for something small in Tipton, we cut to 3026 and something has changed for ever, and it is never the same cut twice. A painted line down the middle of Aldous's corridor. A slow wristband. The Department opening its first incident in two hundred years using the procedure for a pigeon. Livestock overhead. A calendar that no longer says 3026. The smaller her ask, the larger the change. That game is heightened in every sequence and explored in every 3026 scene, which is why the film can run a hundred minutes on it.

6. Characters

A handful, each with a job you can hold in one phrase.

- **Aldous**, 3026. *The most bored man in the most boring year in history*. Mid-forties to look at, two hundred and eleven in fact, still junior. Precise, gentle and desperate for something to go wrong. Never smiles until the last shot.

- **Dawn Mercer**, 56, 14 Hollies Drive, Tipton. *A lollipop lady given the most powerful tool ever made, who uses it on a man in the medium lane.* Twenty-seven years on the crossing outside Hollies Primary. Sixty lengths at the baths at half six every morning for twenty-two years, the only forty minutes a day when nobody needs her to stop anything for them. Gives every child its full name, and gives everything else its full name too, including the software. Has done the safeguarding course. Twice.
- **Graham**, 74, No. 16. *The breaststroker who stops to chat.* Head up, glasses on, stops at every end to ask whoever is there how their mother is. The nicest man in the Black Country. He did the Hollies crossing before Dawn, trained her in 1999, gave her the lollipop and taught her the words she has said every day since: "Wait till I say." He is also her next-door neighbour, and she has left by her own back gate for twenty years so that he will not see her, because if Graham sees you, you are twenty minutes. In a swimming cap he does not know her. Always wanted to go up in a microlight at Tenby. They would not have him, with his knee.
- **Jordan**, 19, the lifeguard. *The lad who said "It's a guide."* Does whatever he is told, and so rises further than anyone in the film.
- **Theo Oduya**, 11, No. 12. *The boy it was meant for.* Polite, patient, and posts a note through Dawn's door every day asking for his parcel. The notes get more legal.
- **Wayne Pritchard**, of Wednesbury. *The only driver in twenty-seven years who did not stop.* Silver Vectra, fourteenth of March 2011, eight forty-one in the morning. She has the registration.
- **Honor**, 3026. *Aldous's line manager, who has never had a feeling and is about to have all of them.* Three hundred years in post. Keeper of the pigeon procedure. The sceptic who becomes the lanes' greatest believer.
- **The newsreader**, 3026. *The chorus.* Reads the news every night. We hear the future change in his voice.

Accent. Everybody in 2026 is Black Country: Tipton, Dudley, Wednesbury. It lives in the grammar and the rhythm, never spelled out phonetically. Everybody in 3026 speaks perfect received pronunciation. As Dawn's influence spreads through history, 3026 slides into Black Country, one vowel at a time, and by the last sequence the newsreader is broad Dudley and nobody in 3026 has noticed. It is a joke you can hear on a voice note with your eyes shut.

7. Structure, and why

The spine is the Circle, Dan Harmon's eight steps: You, Need, Go, Search, Find, Take, Return, Change. **The engine inside it is the Game of the Scene:** the one unusual thing, her small ask changing the next thousand years, heightened and explored in every sequence. That is the combination story-structures.md calls the strongest available: the game supplies the laughs beat by beat, the circle supplies the shape and the ending.

Why this and not the others:

- **Not the Snowball on its own.** Every short we have made is a Snowball, and a Snowball saturates. Heighten one thing for a hundred minutes and it hits the point where more stops being funnier. Dawn's builds are still a snowball, but they sit inside a circle, so there is somewhere to come back to.
- **The circle was built for this.** Harmon made it for short comedy and then ran two high-concept comedies on it, one of them about a man dragged across time and space by a scientist. It is proven on exactly this kind of story.
- **Eight steps, eight sequences.** One step per sequence, twelve to fifteen minutes each, and the whole thing is legible on one listen.
- **Two people travel it in opposite directions.** He needs something to happen. She needs nothing to happen in her lane. By the end each has got the other's wish.

- **The last shot rhymes with the first**, same desk, same telephone, and it means the opposite. That rhyme is the ending's last laugh.

The last two sequences run as a farce convergence, and everybody who arrives on that school field is brought there by their own grudge or their own ask. The one exception is the Prime Minister, and he is there because somebody put him on the list.

The tone bar is Taking Back Tuesday. A steady build of smaller laughs, every minute climbing towards a few huge ones. Each sequence below names the huge laugh it is building to. The biggest in the film, in order of size:

1. **The helicopter, sequence eight.** "Can we go?" "She hasn't said." It is Benidorm paying off with a Prime Minister in it, and it climbs from there until the head of the government is made to say "Thank you, Mrs Mercer."
2. **"Can he go?" "I haven't said."**, sequence four. A man at a hotel pool door at noon, burnt down one side, because she will not look at him.
3. **The scan.** "He wants his head looking at", sequence two, paid off fifty minutes later on Question Time: "I'd like to thank her for the scan." A setup at minute twenty that pays off at minute seventy is the thing a feature can do and a short cannot.

Behind those three: the pigs, and the boarding pass.

8. The beat sheet

Sequence one. Nothing Has Happened. 0 to 13 minutes. *You.*

The newsreader: "Good evening. Nothing has happened." Aldous at his desk, the telephone that has never rung, the pigeon in its case. Honor walks him through his annual review, which takes four seconds, because nothing has happened. The Hall of Finished Things, the glass case, the last words ever typed: *That'll do.*

Then the archive, the complaints, the golden age of wanting, and Theo's maths book. Aldous fills in the one form nobody has ever used, and it is approved before he has finished the signature. He names the tool from the paperback. He writes a card, *For Theo. Build whatever you think is necessary*, puts a photograph of the maths-book drawing on the list for Theo to find, and sets the laptop one standing job: every quarter of an hour, do whatever is on the list. He keeps the phone, and pairs the two with a code on the screen, the way anybody does. The parcel goes.

By minute eight we are in Tipton, on a wet Tuesday in October 2026. A courier van. Number 12 is out. The courier knocks at 14. In 3026, Aldous's phone lights up with the delivery photograph: the most important parcel in human history on the wrong doormat. Title: LEFT WITH NEIGHBOUR.

Then Dawn's world, fast. Ten past six in the morning, in the dark, Dawn leaves her house by the back gate, over the flowerbed. Over the fence, at No. 16, Graham is on his front step in his dressing gown calling "Morning!" to an empty road. She has gone out the back for twenty years.

The baths at twenty to seven, the medium lane, where Dawn in a cap and goggles is going round a man for the thirtieth time. Graham, hanging on the rail at the end, talking to Jordan.

GRAHAM: I did the crossing at Hollies, you know. I trained the woman who's on it now.

JORDAN: Is she good?

GRAHAM: Best I ever saw. Steps out, looks them in the eye. They always stop. *(beat)* I never see her now. I expect she's busy.

Dawn goes past. In the cap, he doesn't know her.

GRAHAM: Morning!

She doesn't answer.

The crossing outside Hollies Primary: hi-vis, white cap, lollipop. "Wait till I say." She steps out and looks the driver in the eye, and he stops. A boy from Reception stops dead in the middle of the road to pick up a worm. A van revs, and the driver leans out.

DRIVER: Come on!

DAWN: *(not looking at him)* He's allowed.

The boy carries the worm the rest of the way on both hands, and Dawn waits. "In you go, Kacper Zielinski. Mind that worm." Every child gets its full name. Theo is the one who says thank you.

Theo, waiting at the kerb, asks her why her hair is wet.

DAWN: There's a man in my lane. I asked the lifeguard to move him.

THEO: What did he say?

DAWN: He said it's not a rule. It's a guide.

THEO: What did you say?

DAWN: Nothing. *(a pause)* I did my sixty.

THEO: How long does sixty take you?

DAWN: Forty minutes. *(a pause)* It took fifty-two.

Set piece: 3026 itself, one boring wonder after another, each played as grand, and then the rail.

Escalation: from the most bored man alive to the only man in a thousand years to do anything; from a woman who stops traffic for a living to a woman who cannot get past one pensioner. **The huge laugh it builds to:** the delivery photograph arriving in 3026 and the title over it. The sequence's button is "It took fifty-two."

Sequence two. It's A Guide. 13 to 26 minutes. Need.

She is the neighbour everybody leaves parcels with. The card says For Theo. She does not give it to Theo.

DAWN: You don't give an eleven-year-old a laptop off a stranger.

COURIER: I'm just the courier.

DAWN: I've done the course. *(a pause)* Twice.

She opens it on safeguarding grounds. A dark screen, orange edges, a button that says Summon. And a list down the side, with a line on it she did not write: *Hello Theo. Do not be alarmed. I am writing to you from the year 3026.* A quarter of an hour later the machine has ticked it off and moved it to the finished

section at the bottom. The most important message in human history, done. She writes underneath: *This is Mrs Mercer from No. 14. Theo is eleven. Who is this.* In 3026, Aldous reads it and puts his head on his desk. His reply arrives signed Aldi.

He asks her to give the laptop to Theo. She tells him what she thinks of men on the internet who want laptops given to children. So he proves he is from the future the only way the archive allows: *At 6.52 tomorrow a man in the medium lane will lose his glasses in the deep end.* At 6.52, Graham's glasses go down. Dawn watches them sink. She is not convinced Aldi is from the future. She is convinced he is useful.

Theo's first note comes through her door. *Please may I have my parcel. Theo, No. 12.* She puts it on the side.

That night she writes the first ask on the list, in her own words: *Something that tells people which lane to be in.* And underneath it, because she has been thinking about Graham at the rail, and forgetting it is the list and not a note to Aldi: *He wants his head looking at.* A quarter of an hour later the job picks both up, and windows open on the screen, one under another. By teatime the next day there is a thing. It times you over one length, puts you in a lane, and the printer in her hall prints you a wristband: SLOW, MEDIUM or FAST. She names it after the words she says every morning: Wait Till I Say. She gives the thing that built it its full name, the way she does everything.

She tells Jordan, poolside.

DAWN: I've never made anything in my life. I wrote it on the list and Code Overlord had it done by teatime. *(a pause)* It's from the future, apparently. *(a pause)* It wanted a direct debit.

JORDAN: For something from the future?

DAWN: Eighteen pound a month.

Jordan takes it on the spot, because it means he never has to decide anything again. Then Graham's assessment. One length, head up, timed, the whole baths watching. He stops halfway to ask the timekeeper how her mother is. He finishes in eleven minutes. The printer in Dawn's hall, a mile away, prints SLOW. Graham reads it, says "Fair enough," and asks if anyone wants a biscuit.

Half six the next morning. Dawn swims sixty lengths in an empty medium lane. Forty minutes. The first since September. Not a sound but the water.

A week later she is in the hall with her card statement. Six hundred and forty pounds. On the mat beneath it, a card. *Dear Dawn. Thank you ever so much for the scan. Lovely staff. Nothing there, they said.* Graham.

In 3026, Aldous walks into work and there is a painted line down the middle of the corridor that was not there yesterday.

"Honor. When did we get a line?"

"We've always had the line."

Set piece: Graham's lane assessment. **Escalation:** from a woman who has never made anything to a working system, a lane, a wristband, a printer, and a private scan she never meant to buy. **The huge laugh it builds to:** the scan card on the mat, "Nothing there, they said", with the six hundred and forty pounds in her other hand. On the way there: Graham stopping mid-length to ask about the timekeeper's mother, and the wristband a mile away printing SLOW.

Sequence three. Think Bigger. 26 to 39 minutes. Go.

Half six. Empty lane, sixty lengths, forty minutes. She climbs out, and from the slow lane comes laughter. Graham has three people round him and somebody has brought a flask. He waves. "Lovely swim!" He still does not know who she is. She goes to the lifeguard's chair.

DAWN: They're talking in the slow lane.

JORDAN: It's the slow lane.

DAWN: They're enjoying it.

Jordan checks the back of his own hi-vis for a rule. There is not one.

That night, on the list: *Something that shows Graham where he was*. By four in the morning the printer in her hall has made a heat map of every length Graham has swum since the fourteenth of September, rebuilt from the timing pads, with a red smear straight down the middle of her lane. Forty-one sheets of A3, one for each time she went round him. She takes them to the baths in a bag for life and hands them to him poolside, one at a time.

GRAHAM: Is that me?

DAWN: That's you.

GRAHAM: I never knew I went so wobbly. *(a pause)* Can I keep these?

The next week they are framed in the café. The café sells them as prints. Graham signs them. She buys one, because she needs to see what he wrote. *Fair enough. G.*

That night, in capitals, in her own writing: *THINK BIGGER*. In 3026, Aldous watches it arrive and slowly takes his hand off the phone. From here on he is the one trying to slow her down.

A quarter of an hour later the machine does exactly that, to Wait Till I Say. It takes on the whole leisure centre. Treadmills in lanes. The sauna seated by how much heat you can stand. The café queue split in two, KNOWS WHAT THEY WANT and STILL LOOKING AT THE BOARD. A one-way system in the changing rooms, with arrows that arrived laminated by courier. Jordan gets a hi-vis with the name on the back. The baths go from two stars to five.

Graham appeals, for the principle of the thing, and Dawn has Code Overlord build an appeals process, because that is only fair. It is heard in the sauna, because the sauna is the only room with tiered seating, and the panel sits in towels in order of rank.

CHAIR: *(in a towel)* You were timed at eleven minutes.

GRAHAM: I stopped.

CHAIR: For how long?

GRAHAM: Her mother'd had a fall.

(On the second tier, the timekeeper, in a towel, nods.)

CHAIR: Appeal dismissed.

GRAHAM: Fair enough. *(to the timekeeper)* How is she?

TIMEKEEPER: Much better, thanks.

GRAHAM: Oh, good.

It is another eleven minutes before anybody can leave the sauna.

In 3026, everyone has a coloured wristband. Honor's is green. Aldous has been given a slow one.

"I'm not slow."

"It's a guide."

Aldous has watched her aim the most powerful tool in history at a leisure centre, and he decides to state the mission, plainly, once. He writes the reason for the whole parcel, in capitals: *HUMANITY MUST FLY*.

A quarter of an hour later the printer in Dawn's hall starts up on its own. A boarding pass. Birmingham to Alicante, Saturday, ten past six in the morning. The machine had her card from the direct debit. The next morning she shows it to Jordan.

DAWN: It says I've got to fly.

JORDAN: Have you flown before?

DAWN: I've been to Rhyl.

Set piece: the sauna tribunal. **Escalation:** one lane becomes a map of one man becomes a whole building run on her rules. **The huge laugh it builds to:** HUMANITY MUST FLY, the printer, the boarding pass, Rhyl.

Sequence four. Fly. 39 to 52 minutes. Search.

She goes, because it is booked and it would be a waste. She takes Jordan, because he has never been either, and the lollipop, in the hold, because she does not go anywhere without it. When she shuts the laptop for take-off the job carries on without it, on a machine somewhere else; her phone says RUNNING REMOTELY and she tells the woman next to her it is her nephew.

At home the notes pile up behind her door. Number nine: *The courier says the photograph shows your mat. I have enclosed the photograph.*

A hotel in Benidorm, six in the morning. Four hundred British holidaymakers behind a glass door with towels over their arms like waiters, the ancient war of the sunloungers about to start. Dawn looks at it the way she looks at a crossing. By nine Wait Till I Say has a sunlounger system: a lane for each row, a slot for each towel, laminated signs from a print shop on the strip, and everybody's walk from their room to the pool timed. The hotel adopts it on the Tuesday.

And at the front of the queue, towel over his shoulder, is Wayne Pritchard, of Wednesbury. Silver Vectra. Fourteenth of March 2011, eight forty-one in the morning, the only driver in twenty-seven years who did not stop for her. She has the registration. She has never mentioned it to anybody.

JORDAN: Do you know him?

DAWN: No.

The next morning, lollipop up. "Wait till I say." Four hundred wait, in silence. At 6.04 a man from Walsall lifts one flip-flop over the line. Four hundred heads turn. Nobody says a word. He puts the flip-flop back, then walks the whole length of the queue with his towel on his arm and stands at the back. Dawn waits till he

gets there. The sun comes up. She says. Three hundred and ninety-nine towels land at once.

Wayne is still at the door. When she said it, she looked every one of them in the eye except him.

At noon he is still there, burnt down one side.

JORDAN: Can he go?

DAWN: I haven't said.

The photograph on the front of the British papers the next day, LANE LADY, has Wayne in the background, at the door, holding his towel.

In 3026 the newsreader looks at the camera. "Good evening." A pause. "Something has happened." It is the first time in two hundred and fifteen years. The Department of Incidents must open an incident, and it has only one procedure on file. Honor reads it aloud to a room of four-hundred-year-olds in their best clothes.

HONOR: Step one. Open a window.

Somebody opens a window.

HONOR: Step two. Avoid sudden movements. Step three. Do not attempt to feed it.

ALDOUS: It's a woman in Tipton.

HONOR: *(a pause)* Then we shall need a very big window.

The Standing Committee on the Pigeon, appointed in 2811 and never convened, is convened. Dawn's official designation in 3026 is the Pigeon.

Set piece: the sunlounger dawn. **Escalation:** Tipton becomes Spain becomes the front page, and her oldest grudge turns up at the front of the queue. **The huge laugh it builds to:** "Can he go?" "I haven't said." A man at a pool door at noon, burnt down one side, because she will not look at him. The 3026 button: "Then we shall need a very big window."

Sequence five. Everybody Gets A Go. 52 to 65 minutes. Find. The midpoint.

She comes home to nineteen reporters at the crossing, a council that wants the app and a man from National Highways on her doorstep with a folder. Everybody wants it, and Dawn believes in one thing above everything: at a crossing, everybody gets to cross. So she writes: *Let everybody have a go.* A quarter of an hour later the machine has built a website and put Code Overlord on it for anybody who wants it. That is how it reached the world. By the Monday a million people in Britain are asking it for things, and not one of them wants to fly. The most-built thing in the country that week tells you whether next door's hedge is over the line.

At night the list is where she and Aldous become friends. He tells her nobody in 3026 has ever asked him what he wants. She asks. He says: something to happen. He tells her about the statue in the archive.

"Nine storey?"

"Yes."

"Where've they put it?"

"Tipton."

A pause. "Where in Tipton?"

"All of it."

Then he writes the thing he has asked for since the first night: *Theo should have the laptop*. And she writes back, the way anybody in the Black Country would: *And pigs might fly*.

Both lines are on the list, so both get done. At quarter past eleven that night there is a courier at No. 14 to collect a laptop. Dawn cannot stop him. She watches him walk it next door. No. 12 is in bed and does not answer. The courier comes back up her path.

COURIER: Can you take one for twelve?

DAWN: (*a long pause*) Give it here.

In the finished section: *Theo should have the laptop*. Ticked. In 3026, Aldous's phone lights up with a delivery photograph: the same laptop on the same doormat. He puts his head on his desk.

Tipton, first light. A pig in a harness under eight propellers crosses the Owen Street at head height, in no hurry. The machine found the rig in the photograph on the list, Theo's maths-book drawing, and a pig is wearing it. It hired the pigs from a city farm in Walsall.

On the list, from 3026: *The pigs are flying*. And from Tipton: *That's not flying. It is over your house. It's hovering*.

Seven the next morning, the city farm car park. Dawn with a stopwatch and a clipboard, having every pig assessed over one length. The printer in her hall, a mile away: SLOW. SLOW. SLOW. Forty pigs, every one of them slow.

REPORTER: Mrs Mercer, are the pigs flying?

DAWN: They're in the slow lane.

By the Friday there are forty pigs over Tipton, and because there is traffic in the sky now, Wait Till I Say has put the sky over Tipton in lanes.

Theo's note, number sixty-one: a photograph of a pig over his house, circled in felt tip. Number sixty-two: the dictionary's entry for *fly*, highlighted.

In 3026, Aldous walks to work under a sky full of pigs in coloured wristbands. The slow lane is mostly pigs.

"Honor. When did we get the pigs?"

"We've always had the pigs."

Then the institution tries to stop her, and cannot, because of its own rules. Dawn is summoned before the Transport Select Committee to explain how a lollipop lady's app became the way Britain drives. Jordan carries the laptop. The committee clerks installed Wait Till I Say on the Monday, to keep things fair.

CHAIR: Mrs Mercer, can you tell the committee, in your own words, and I'd like first to put on record my own long-standing interest in road safety, which goes back to my time on the county council, when...

A printer starts up somewhere in the Palace of Westminster. The Chair's wristband reads SLOW. He is moved to the end of the table. His microphone follows him.

The only member in the fast lane is a backbencher who has not been called in nine years. She has nothing prepared.

MP: Did you enjoy Benidorm?

DAWN: Yes.

MP: No further questions.

The committee moves to suspend the app. To move a motion you have to be called, and everybody who wants it suspended talks too long to be called. A point of order is raised, and the system puts points of order in the slow lane, where they have always been. The report runs to a hundred and twelve pages, and its one recommendation, at paragraph 4.3, is that the country should wait till she says. The Government accepts it without reading it. It is now law. On the way out, the Chair, from the end of the table, says the Prime Minister really ought to get up to Tipton, to the crossing where it all started, and somebody says put it on the list. Jordan is holding the laptop. He puts it on the list. He is offered a job at the Department for Transport before he reaches the lift, because he does what he is told.

The midpoint image. Aldous walks out of the Department of Incidents and 3026 has changed completely. The whole city is in lanes, painted, coloured, arrowed, pigs overhead. The calendar no longer says 3026. It says 1000 After Dawn. And over the city, nine storeys high, in bronze, a woman in a hi-vis and a white cap holding up a lollipop, and cut into the plinth: WAIT TILL I SAY. The Department of Incidents now has forty thousand staff, all of them processing Tipton, and Aldous has been promoted to a desk with four telephones. None of them has rung. They are all engaged.

The newsreader, and he has picked up something in his vowels: "Good evening. A great deal has happened."

Aldous stands in the middle of it and laughs, for the first time in two hundred years.

Set piece: the Select Committee. **Escalation:** one woman's app becomes everybody's tool and then the law of the land, and a turn of phrase becomes livestock in the sky. **The huge laugh it builds to:** "And pigs might fly", the pig crossing the Owen Street at head height in no hurry, and Dawn assessing forty of them: "They're in the slow lane." The 3026 button: "We've always had the pigs."

Sequence six. Mother: Fine. 65 to 78 minutes. Take.

Aldous tries to slow her down the way 2026 always slowed anything down. It is on every page of the archive. He writes on the list: *Set up an independent review*. A quarter of an hour later the machine has done it: terms of reference, a chair, a call for evidence, a hundred and forty submissions, a public hearing in Dudley Town Hall, a draft, a consultation on the draft, and the final report, bound, on the mat in Dawn's hall at twenty past. It recommends extending Wait Till I Say to the Isle of Man.

ALDOUS: They took eleven years.

HONOR: Who did?

ALDOUS: Reviews. They took eleven years. That was what they were for.

HONOR: *(reading the Isle of Man paragraph)* It's very thorough.

Meanwhile the slow lane has become a movement, and Graham never meant it to. Question Time comes from a leisure centre in Walsall, the audience seated in lanes and wearing wristbands. Graham has brought a flask.

WOMAN IN A FLEECE: My question's for Mrs Mercer. My mother's ninety-one and she's been put in the slow lane at the big Asda.

DAWN: How long does her shop take her?

WOMAN: About three hours.

DAWN: Then she's in the right lane.

Silence. One man claps, and stops.

GRAHAM: Is that the Wednesbury one? Lovely café.

A roar.

CHAIR: Graham, you've been assessed, appealed against and given a lane of your own. Anything you'd like to say to Mrs Mercer?

GRAHAM: I'd like to thank her for the scan.

Dawn's face.

GRAHAM: I trained her, you know. Ninety-nine. She's gone past me four thousand times since September. *(beat)* Never once said hello.

CHAIR: Mrs Mercer?

DAWN: *(a long time)* I was doing my lengths.

GRAHAM: Fair enough.

They stand for him.

That night she writes the last ask. Every rung before it has worked and made things better, and this is the one that works best of all. It is aimed at the thing Graham stops at every end to do.

Something so nobody has to ask after anybody's mother.

By teatime every wristband in Britain has a second line. MOTHER: FINE. MOTHER: HIP. MOTHER: IN TENERIFE. It updates on the hour. The next morning Graham reaches the end of the slow lane, reads Jordan's wrist, and his face lights up. "Oh, she's had it done!" He is there eleven minutes. He has never had so much to go on.

So she adds the weather in Tenby. Then everybody's dog. Then, in capitals: *EVERYTHING GRAHAM MIGHT ASK ANYBODY*. By April the wristband is a sleeve from wrist to elbow, and the country stops speaking, because every answer is already on your arm. Two women pass in the Co-op, the right distance apart, and neither says sorry, because there is nothing to say it for. In 3026, beside the pigeon, there is a new glass case: SORRY. Last said Tipton, 2027.

In 3026, everybody wears a sleeve and nobody speaks. At lunch, Honor eats opposite a very small, very old woman. Honor's sleeve says MOTHER: FINE. The old woman's says DAUGHTER: FINE.

ALDOUS: Honor. Is that your mother?

HONOR: Yes.

ALDOUS: When did you two last speak?

HONOR: *(a pause)* The pigeon.

Half six at the baths. Forty swimmers, each in a lane, nobody speaking. Graham has stopped coming. There is nobody left who needs asking anything.

Then her crossing. The council writes to say the lollipop crossings are being replaced by Wait Till I Say, hers first, because it is famous. The letter comes off the printer in her own hall, from her own app. Then the printer keeps going.

SLOW.

The newsreader, back in perfect received pronunciation: "Good evening. Nothing has happened." A pause. "In an orderly fashion."

Aldous writes UNDO on the list in capitals. A quarter of an hour later the machine undoes the last thing on it, which was Dawn's line from the night before: *Night, Aldi*. Then Honor turns to the last page of the pigeon procedure. "Step four. Close the window." At midnight the list goes dead.

Set piece: Question Time. **Escalation:** the last ask, the one that works best of all, silences a country and costs her the crossing. **The huge laugh it builds to:** her own printer, after her own redundancy letter, printing her a wristband that says SLOW. And in 3026, "The pigeon."

Sequence seven. Returns. 78 to 92 minutes. Return.

Small objects, no persons. Aldous folds himself into the largest box the form allows, addresses it to Mrs D. Mercer, 14 Hollies Drive, fills the form in perfectly, and hands it to Honor, who cannot refuse a form that has been filled in perfectly. She stamps it. Her hand is shaking. It is the first feeling she has ever had, and she does not know where to put it.

Tipton, eight in the morning. A courier, a large box. Number 14 is out; Dawn is at the crossing she is no longer allowed to do. Left with neighbour: No. 16. From inside the box, politely: "Excuse me." Graham opens it with the bread knife, and cuts himself a slice on the way back to the kitchen. A man in a white suit from the year 3026 unfolds out of the cardboard onto his hall carpet.

GRAHAM: You'll want a tea.

The kitchen. Aldous holding his first tea.

GRAHAM: Where've you come from?

ALDOUS: The year 3026.

GRAHAM: *(a pause)* Did you come up the M6?

ALDOUS: No.

GRAHAM: You're better off.

Graham puts a bag of pork scratchings in front of him. Aldous has only ever tasted Pleasant. He eats one. It takes a long time.

ALDOUS: What is it?

GRAHAM: Pig.

Through the window, in the rain, at head height, in no hurry, a pig goes past in a harness. Aldous watches it all the way across.

ALDOUS: Which one?

Graham asks him how his mother is, out loud, with no sleeve to read, and Aldous has no idea, and it is the best question anybody has ever asked him. On the fridge there is a photograph of the microlights at Tenby. "They wouldn't have me," says Graham, "with my knee."

Aldous borrows the phone to ring the council about Dawn's crossing. Sandwell Council puts him on hold. "Your call is important to us. You are number fourteen in the queue." He has never waited for anything in two hundred and eleven years. He sits on the bottom stair holding the handset in both hands. Forty minutes of Vivaldi. Number nine. Number four. Graham brings him a tea and says nothing, which for Graham is love. At last a woman answers.

ALDOUS: Hello. *(a pause)* Could you put me back?

Dawn comes home from the crossing she cannot do. On her mat, a card: *Sorry we missed you. Your parcel is with No. 16.* She stands in the hall holding it for a long time. There is no back gate to somebody else's front door. She knocks.

GRAHAM: Dawn! I never see you.

DAWN: I've come for my parcel.

GRAHAM: He's having a tea.

DAWN: Can I have him?

GRAHAM: When he's finished his tea.

She stands in the kitchen of the man she has gone out the back to avoid for twenty years while a visitor from the future finishes a tea. It takes eleven minutes. Graham asks her how her mother is. Then Aldous looks up.

"Aldi."

"It's Aldous."

"It said Aldi."

The two of them in the same century at last, across Graham's kitchen table.

DAWN: Is it bad? Up there?

ALDOUS: It's orderly.

DAWN: *(a pause)* Is that bad?

ALDOUS: I've been on hold for forty minutes this morning. *(a pause)* It's the best day of my life.

GRAHAM: *(from the sink)* Vivaldi.

He asks her for the one thing he has asked from the beginning, the laptop, for Theo. And Dawn, who believes in one thing above everything, that everybody gets a go, sees that there is one person on Hollies Drive who never got his. The notes are on the side, in a pile. Number forty-four, typed: *Further to my previous notes*. Number ninety: a page of the Consumer Rights Act, highlighted. Number a hundred and fifty: a small claims form, filled in, in felt tip, with "age of claimant" left blank. Number two hundred and twelve came this morning.

She knocks at No. 12. Theo opens the door holding a clipboard.

THEO: Can you sign for it, please. *(a pause)* And print your name.

By ten Theo has the laptop on his kitchen table and the maths book open beside it. Aldous tells him who it is for. Theo writes on the list: the pig rig, but for a person. Windows open, one under another, and keep opening. The parts arrive by courier at two, and the city farm in Walsall lends him a harness.

Meanwhile a helicopter is on its way. The Prime Minister's visit to the crossing where it all started was put on the list at the Select Committee, and the list gets done. It is in the diary for quarter past three and it cannot be moved. The pilot is from Wednesbury.

Set piece: the unboxing, and a man from the future discovering the council's hold music. **Escalation:** everybody who must not meet is heading for one school field at home time, each for a reason of their own. **The huge laugh it builds to:** "Could you put me back?" On the way: the bread knife, "You're better off", "Which one?", and Theo at the door with the clipboard.

Sequence eight. Wait Till I Say. 92 to 105 minutes. Change.

Quarter past three. Home time. The school field, the crossing, the cameras, the Prime Minister's helicopter coming in low over the rooftops. And on the grass behind the goalposts, the maths book, built: a harness under eight propellers, tested on livestock.

Graham has always wanted to go up. They strap him in. At the back, Theo puts his hand up: "Excuse me. That's mine." Nobody hears him. It lifts Graham off the grass, up over the school, up over the crossing, horizontal in the harness, and because he is horizontal and in the air, he does what he does. Head-up breaststroke. Glasses on. Over Tipton.

The system, working perfectly, finds a slow object in the medium lane of the sky and the Prime Minister's helicopter coming the other way. On Jordan's screen: REMOVE SLOW OBJECT. Jordan, in a Department for Transport suit, turns to Dawn. He is nineteen and he is holding a tablet.

JORDAN: It says move him.

DAWN: Is it right?

JORDAN: Code Overlord's never been wrong once.

DAWN: *(a pause)* He's allowed.

Dawn steps off the kerb she has not been allowed off for four months. She walks into the middle of the playing field, looks up, and looks the pilot of the Prime Minister's helicopter in the eye. It is Wayne Pritchard. She holds up her lollipop.

The helicopter stops.

Graham breaststrokes up level with the open door, stops, and reads the pilot's sleeve. MOTHER: HIP.

GRAHAM: Is it the left?

WAYNE: *(over the rotors)* The right.

Graham settles in, treading air, nodding, and Wayne, who has not spoken to anybody since April, tells him about the hip: the waiting list, the physio she doesn't like, the frame she won't use. Graham taps the windscreen. "Sorry, love. I'll not be a minute." Dawn, on the field, hears it. Seven months. Four thousand lengths. A heat map, a tribunal, a sleeve, an Act of Parliament. And he has said it to Wayne Pritchard. In 3026, the glass case beside the pigeon is empty.

Graham gets across. The lollipop stays up. The Prime Minister slides his window open.

PRIME MINISTER: Can we go?

WAYNE: She hasn't said.

PRIME MINISTER: Can she do that?

AIDE: It's the law, Prime Minister.

PRIME MINISTER: Whose law?

AIDE: Yours.

Wayne slides the door back and shouts down over the rotors, fifteen years of it.

WAYNE: Fourteenth of March, two thousand and eleven! I was late for the dentist! I'm sorry about the Vectra!

DAWN: What Vectra?

The lollipop goes up another inch.

PRIME MINISTER: What Vectra?

WAYNE: Don't.

Ten minutes. Twenty. Her arm starts to go, and Jordan comes and holds her elbow up without being asked. The bell goes, and the children come out to the crossing, see her on the field holding up a helicopter, and stand at the kerb, because nobody has said. The fuel light comes on. The helicopter comes down in the long-jump pit. The Prime Minister climbs out with sand in his shoes and needs to get across the Owen Street to his car.

Dawn walks back to the kerb. "Wait till I say." She steps out, looks the traffic in the eye, and it stops, all of it, for her, for the first time in four months. The children cross first. Theo, at the back, says "Thank you, Mrs Mercer." The Prime Minister crosses in the middle of Year 3 with sand in his shoes, reaches the far kerb and walks off.

DAWN: What do we say?

He stops. Forty children look at him.

PRIME MINISTER: Thank you.

DAWN: Thank you, Mrs Mercer.

PRIME MINISTER: Thank you, Mrs Mercer.

Above them all, Graham is still up there. He looks down at the crossing and asks the only thing she has wanted since September.

GRAHAM: Am I in your way, Dawn?

She looks at him for a long time. The whole field waits.

DAWN: Yes.

(a pause)

DAWN: Go on, then.

GRAHAM: Fair enough.

He breaststrokes off towards Wednesbury, delighted.

In 3026 the newsreader looks at the camera, and he is pure Dudley now. "Evening. Summat's happened."

Half past five. The post office. Last collection. Aldous has to go home the way he came, and he goes as a return. The counter clerk asks whether the contents are fragile, and he says "Me." Dawn walks him to the counter. She has one thing for him, and she writes it on a scrap of paper, not the list, so that nothing will make him do it. He folds it and gets in the box.

Set piece: the helicopter. **Escalation:** the whole machine, working perfectly, overruled by one woman with a stick and a grudge from 2011, and kept overruled well past the point anybody would stop. **The huge laugh it builds to:** a chain, each link bigger than the last. "Can we go?" "She hasn't said." Then "Whose law?" "Yours." Then "What Vectra?" Then the head of the government, sand in his shoes, corrected like a six-year-old: "Thank you, Mrs Mercer."

9. The ending

The film leaves the ground in both centuries at once, and the software never fails in either.

In 2026 the leaving is literal: a pensioner breaststroking over the Black Country in a rig first tested on pigs, and the Prime Minister held in the sky by a lollipop and a four-word Act of Parliament, then landed in a long-jump pit and walked across the road with Year 3. Two ending families run together. **Absurd success**, played completely flat: a lollipop lady has halted the head of the government in mid-air, and nobody on the field treats that as the remarkable part; the remarkable part, to everybody there, is that she has her crossing back. And **she overrules the machine**. Its answer was correct, and she says so, and she names it: Code Overlord has never been wrong once. The slow object was in the wrong lane of the sky. She rejected it for a human reason, in two words she first said in minute ten about a boy with a worm: "He's allowed."

In 3026 the leaving is the circle closing. Aldous climbs out of his box at the Department of Incidents and walks back to his desk past the Hall of Finished Things, where the last words on the old screen no longer say *That'll do*. They say *Go on, then*. Out of the window, people are flying: in lanes, in coloured wristbands,

some of them pigs, in the first rain for six hundred years, and everybody is complaining about it. In the medium lane of the sky a slow man is doing head-up breaststroke, and people are shouting at him.

At his desk, exactly as in the opening, he unfolds her scrap of paper. *Ring when you get there.* It is what every woman in the Black Country says at a coach station. He looks at the telephone. There is nobody to ring. It has been a thousand years.

Then the telephone that has never rung, rings, and for one second the audience thinks it is her.

It is Honor, and she wants to complain.

"Incidents." A pause. "Is he doing breaststroke?"

Aldous smiles, for the first time in the film.

"It's a guide."

Card: CODE OVERLORD. *Build whatever you think is necessary.* Nothing after it.

In the credits, three quick shots. Half six at the baths: Dawn in the medium lane, head up, behind Graham, at his pace, talking. Sports day in July: the helicopter still in the long-jump pit, sand up to the skids, Wayne in the cockpit, his sleeve reading MOTHER: HIP (BOTH), children jumping past the rotor blades, and the PE teacher walking over to the crossing with his whistle. "Can he go?" "I haven't said." And a note coming through Graham's door. *Please may I have my flying machine. Theo, No. 12.* In the corner, small: No. 1.

10. How it sells Code Overlord

Nobody explains anything and nobody names a feature. By the end, a viewer who has never heard of the product knows this:

- **You say what you want in your own words, and it builds you a working thing that keeps working without you.** A woman who has never made anything writes one sentence on a list and by teatime there is a system with a name, wristbands coming off a printer, a lane on the wall.
- **You can keep asking, and it keeps building, as big as you like.** One lane, one building, one country, the sky. Every rung is her asking again, and every rung is another thing that exists.
- **It reaches out of the laptop into the real world.** Printers, couriers, laminated signs, a card payment, a boarding pass, a private scan, an independent review with a hundred and forty submissions, a rig with eight propellers. Whatever she built, strangers used without knowing who made it.
- **One ask can put a lot of workers on it at once, and it runs on a schedule while you sleep or fly.** Windows opening one under another on the screen; a job that picks up the list every quarter of an hour; the phone saying it is running remotely at thirty thousand feet.
- **It lives on your phone as well as your desk.** The list is on both, which is the entire plot.
- **Anybody can use it.** A lollipop lady ran a country with it. An eleven-year-old built the machine in his maths book with it before lunch.
- **It does exactly what you ask.** It never fails, not once, in a hundred minutes. Everything that goes wrong is what somebody asked for, and the last word said about it on screen is that it has never been wrong once. That is the most flattering thing a comedy can say about a piece of software.

The origin story is the brand's own. The name, the Summon button and the whole dark-lord vocabulary come from a bored man in 3026 who localised it from the one paperback that survived, and the way it reached the world is a lollipop lady writing *let everybody have a go*. The company's own story, a product

from 3026 sent to improve the present, becomes a film in which it did, in the most Black Country way available.

What a Code Overlord user sees and nobody else does: the notepad down the side of the screen, the same notepad on the phone, the photograph attached to it, and the section at the bottom where finished things go; a job on a quarter-hourly cadence whose instruction is readable, *do whatever is on the list*; windows opening one under another beneath a single ask; the phone app showing the sessions working, one of them running remotely; the pairing code on the screen before the parcel goes.

How this was made

Written from the skill's references and the eleven short films, then read twice by a panel of five comedians, one agent each, in character, blind to each other, all asked the client's question verbatim and given Taking Back Tuesday as the tonal bar. The five: **Armando Iannucci**, deadpan and long-form, for what committee or form this would generate and whether the plot keeps making new scenes for a hundred minutes; **Larry David**, long-form, for the petty grievance pursued with legal seriousness; **Tim Robinson**, for the exit nobody takes; **Jimmy Carr**, for whether the huge laughs are huge and the funny word comes last; **Victoria Wood**, long-form and warmth, for Black Country speech and whether anybody loves anybody.

Round one verdict: charming, not hilarious. All five found the laughs real and the register right, and all five said the same three things: the huge laughs were pictures rather than jokes (four hundred towels landing is a gasp, not a laugh); Dawn got her empty lane at minute twenty-two and then became a passenger while Aldous wrote her asks; and the middle was a tour, with a montage of the short films that nobody in a cinema would understand. What changed: Dawn now writes every ask herself and wants Graham to admit he was in her way (Robinson), which became the engine; Graham trained her, lives next door and does not know her in a swimming cap (Wood, David); Wayne Pritchard and "I haven't said" (David); the scan, the heat map, the pigs, the Pigeon Protocol, the Select Committee and Question Time as a written scene (Wood, Robinson, Carr, Iannucci); the mother sleeves as the last rung (Robinson); the cameo montage, the Cabinet, the dictation gag, the cup of tea and "Warmly" cut.

Round two verdict: much funnier. Carr: "Much. About twice as funny." David: "Yes. A lot. Somebody finally gave her a grudge she can't win." Iannucci: "Last time the film had a mood." Now it has an engine. Robinson named the biggest laugh as "Can he go?" "I haven't said.", and Wood called it exactly "For one bin?" "At this stage." Against Taking Back Tuesday, the panel's reading is that the feature now has bigger peaks: the helicopter chain and the Benidorm door both beat "At this stage", and Carr counted the scan as this film's "Quite a lot of Dave." Where it was still safe, and what changed: the sorry chorus was a hymn in the middle of a set piece (four of five), so Graham now says sorry once, to the wrong man; the section-two line was a tag on a tag, so it is now "Whose law?" "Yours."; sequences five and six were overstuffed, so the Whitehall run went; Aldous was a man at a window, so he now sets up an independent review that arrives in twenty minutes; sequence seven opened on the stock alien-in-the-rain image, so it now opens on pork scratchings and the council's hold music; the one face-to-face meeting was summarised, so it is written; and the ending ended six times, so the reporter and the skywriter went, and the scrap of paper now makes the telephone matter.

Contradictions, and who won. Wayne's apology: David's "What Vectra?" beat Iannucci's lollipop lowered an inch and Carr's "Do I know you?", because a woman who has kept a registration for fifteen years pretending she has never heard of the car is funnier than her accepting, and it pays off "Do you know him?" "No." from Benidorm. Graham's last question: David's "Yes. Go on, then." "Fair enough." beat Robinson's and Wood's "No", because she only gets the admission by saying it herself and he stays delighted, which is funnier; the warmth moved into the credits truce. "I'm a pilot": cut, with Carr and Wood, against Iannucci

and Robinson who laughed at it, because the pilot's face at the climax is worth more than a wink fifty minutes early. The pigs stayed, with four of five calling them huge, and Robinson's fix went in: the laugh now lands on Dawn assessing forty pigs as slow. The Tenby weather rung and rain on one side of the street were not taken, because stopping the weather is the spent ending of *It Didn't Rain*. The German family in the sunlounger queue went, because two readers called the joke tired. David's Gary Pritchard is renamed Wayne, because Gary is already a name in two of the short films.

The one note still open. Robinson's warning that a list which does everything literally makes the machine a genie, with the audience a step ahead of it. The film now puts the laugh on what Dawn does after each literal delivery rather than on the delivery, but the screenplay should keep testing every list gag against his question: who is choosing here, and is it her?

Three things to decide

1. **The title.** *Left With Neighbour*, recommended, over *Wait Till I Say*, which gives away the climax.
2. **The pigs.** A city farm's pigs in harnesses under propellers are the most talked-about picture in the film and the test flight for the ending. Recommended as written, gently, at head height, in no hurry, with a vet in the credits, because a pig that looks mistreated stops being funny in the same second.
3. **The Prime Minister.** Recommended unnamed, of no party and never a likeness, because the joke is the office being made to say "Thank you, Mrs Mercer", not a person, and it has to survive a change of government before the film is released.